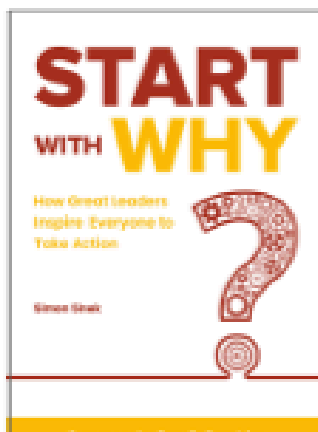




Start with Why

How Great Leaders Inspire
Everyone to Take Action

SIMON SINEK



The Big "So What"

Great leaders and organizations can create sustainable change because they *inspire* others. In the process, they create loyal followers who stick with them through thick and thin, so they can create success again and again. In this book, Sinek explains **what it means to start with WHY**, and how it can create true, lasting success for you and your business.



Manipulation vs Inspiration

It's possible to motivate people through carrots and sticks. However, great leaders - like Steve Jobs, the Wright brothers and Martin Luther King - go beyond that. They inspire people with a deeper sense of purpose or belonging. They touch people in a way that makes them want to go the extra mile. They inspire people by starting with WHY.



Carrots and Sticks

Manipulations are used everywhere in sales and marketing. Although they work, their effects are short-term in nature, and are costly over time. Here are some examples:



Price. When the price is low enough, people will buy. However, dropping prices means less profit, and may not be sustainable in the long run.



Promotions like "buy 1 get 1 free" or cash-back incentives, are also used rampantly to boost short-term sales.



Fear is one of the most powerful forms of manipulation. Marketers and politicians play on our fears, like fear of

KEY QUOTES

"This book is not designed to tell you what to do or how to do it. Its goal is not to give you a course of action. Its goal is to offer you the cause of action."

"Those who are able to inspire will create a following of people - supporters, voters, customers, workers - who act for the good of the whole not because they have to, but because they want to."

"Great leaders are those who trust their gut. They are those who understand the art before the science. They win hearts before minds. They are the ones who start with WHY."

"From businesses to politics, manipulations run rampant in forms of sales and marketing."

"The danger of manipulations that they work...Just because works doesn't make it right."

"Fear, real or perceived, is arguably the most powerful manipulation of the lot."

illness, death, and loss, with messages like, "you must buy or do this, or beware of the consequences..."



Appealing to aspirations is about offering something that people desire, with the promise of achieving it more easily with your solution. It's very effective in motivating a burst of action, but the effects don't last.



Peer pressure. The use of celebrity endorsements, or messages like "4 out of 5 doctors prefer this solution", "over a million satisfied customers have tried this", are all manipulations using peer pressure. They appeal to our fear of being wrong, or being left out.



Novelty. True innovations can transform an industry or society. However most "innovations" in the marketplace (e.g. a new variant of toothpaste or shampoo) are merely tactics that play on the "shiny-object syndrome".



Inspiration, not manipulation

Manipulations work so well that they have become the norm in our society. **Generally, manipulations (or carrots and sticks) work well for one-time transactions**, e.g. a reward for returning a lost dog. Such transactions do not build loyal followers who will stick by you even when you slip up, or when better options emerge. **If you want a lasting relationship built on loyalty, you need to inspire, not manipulate.**



THE GOLDEN CIRCLE

The Golden Circle helps us to understand why we do what we do:



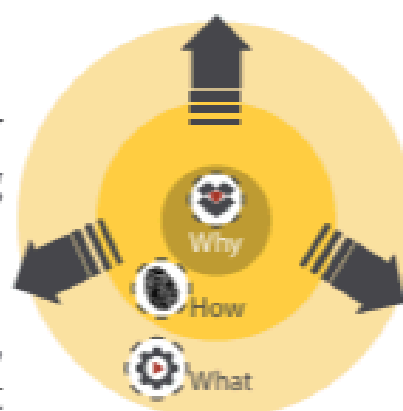
WHY: What's your purpose, belief, or cause? Why do you exist?



HOW: What makes you better or different? What's your unique selling proposition (USP)?



WHAT: What do you do? For example, what's your job function, or what products or services do you sell?



KEY QUOTES

"Peer pressure works not because the majority or the experts are always right, but because we fear that we may be wrong."

"Leadership requires people to stick with you through thick and thin. Leadership is the ability to rally not for a single event, but for years. In business, leadership means that customers will continue to support your company even when you slip up."

"It all starts from the inside out. It all starts with Why."

"When most organizations or people think, act or communicate, they do so from the outside in... We say WHAT we do, we sometimes say HOW we do it, but we rarely say WHY we do WHAT we do."

"People don't buy WHAT you do, they buy WHY you do it."

"Knowing your WHY is not the only way to be successful, but it is the only way to maintain a lasting success and have a greater blend of innovation and flexibility."

The “WHAT” is usually the easiest to define, while the “WHY” is usually the fuzziest. That’s why **most people communicate from outside in** - they explain what they do, how their idea, product, or company is better than others, and most never explain why they exist.

The most impactful and inspiring leaders and organizations do the opposite - they communicate from inside-out. They start with WHY, and the WHATs are merely proof of their beliefs. A strong WHY offers reasons for people to buy, and gives you flexibility to offer a wide range of WHATs as a manifestation of your cause.

For example, Steve Jobs and Steve Wozniak didn’t set out to build a computer company. They started Apple with the ambition to start a revolution. Apple stands for thinking differently, for challenging status quo, for simplifying technology so individuals could have the same power to create as big companies. **Its earliest fans and supporters weren’t just buying computers - they were buying what Apple stood for**; and because Apple’s WHY was so strong, people could relate to a wide range of their products, from the iPod to Mac.

Obviously, good products are important, and you must deliver what you promise. However, **you don’t need the best or perfect product. You need a good-enough product with a strong WHY.** In fact, the technology used by Apple wasn’t even pioneered by them; Apple simply did a superior job of showing us WHY we needed their solutions.



Communicating from Inside-Out

To communicate from inside-out, you’ll need all 3 components – WHY, HOW and WHAT – and you’ll need them in the correct sequence:



Clarity of WHY. To explain WHY you do WHAT you do, you first need to **be clear about your purpose, cause or belief.**



Discipline of HOW. With a clarity of WHY, you can **figure out HOW to get there**, e.g. what values or principles should guide your actions, what systems and processes should be put in place, what type of people or partners you should work with, and how to go about doing it. To establish the HOW, you need to **breakdown vague concepts like “integrity”,**

KEY QUOTES

“It is the cause that is represented by the company, brand, product or person that inspires loyalty.”

“No matter how visionary or how brilliant, a great idea or a great product isn’t worth much if no one buys it.”

“For values or guiding principles to be truly effective they have to be verbs... we have a clear idea of how to act in any situation.”

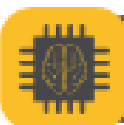
“What authenticity means is that your Golden Circle is in balance. It means that everything you say and everything you do you actually believe.”

“innovation”, or “honesty” into actionable behaviours, that can be articulated in the form of verbs.



Consistency of WHAT. Others assess how coherent and authentic you are, by looking at whether what you do and say are in line with what you believe. **You are authentic when all 3 aspects of your Golden Circle are aligned and in balance.**

Let's take a look at Southwest Airlines. It wasn't the first low-cost airline, but it stood out because it had a clear purpose – to allow the average person to move freely in the United States. It backed up its WHY with a coherent HOW, keeping things cheap, fun and simple. For example, it had only open seating on its flights, and had hot pants and go-go boots for flight-attendant uniforms. When Delta Airlines and United Airlines launched their low-cost airlines subsidiaries, they copied elements of Southwest's “how” and “what”. However, without a clear WHY, their Golden Circle wasn't balanced and they failed.



The WHY and Human Biology

The Golden Circle relates to how we're built biologically.



All human beings have a biological **need to belong**, and we are willing to go out of our way to get that feeling. When we are amongst people who share our beliefs and values, we feel connected and safe. Hence, if people can relate to your WHY, they are more willing to make the extra effort or investment to include your products, brands or companies in their lives.



Our “**limbic brain**”, which is in charge of our decisions, is also the part of our brain that's in charge of feelings, like trust and loyalty. Our neocortex handles analytical thought and language, allowing us to rationalize our decisions and put them into words. Most of us don't try to analyze all possible data before making a decision - It takes too much time and effort, and we usually feel unsure even after processing all the empirical evidence.

On the other hand, when we “follow our heart” or make a “gut decision”, such decisions “feel right”, because they involve

KEY QUOTES

“Gaining clarity of WHY, ironically, is not the hard part. It is the discipline to trust one's gut, to stay true to one's purpose, cause or beliefs. Remaining completely in balance and authentic is the most difficult part.”

“Our need to belong is not rational, but it is a constant that exists across all people in all culture.”

“Our desire to feel like we belong is so powerful that we will go to great lengths, do irrational things and often spend money to get that feeling.”

“The reason gut decisions feel right is because the part of the brain that controls them also controls our feelings.”

“Our behaviour is affected by our assumptions or our perceived truths. We make decisions based on what we think we know.”

our emotions-centred limbic brain. That's why decisions that start with WHY literally win hearts and minds.

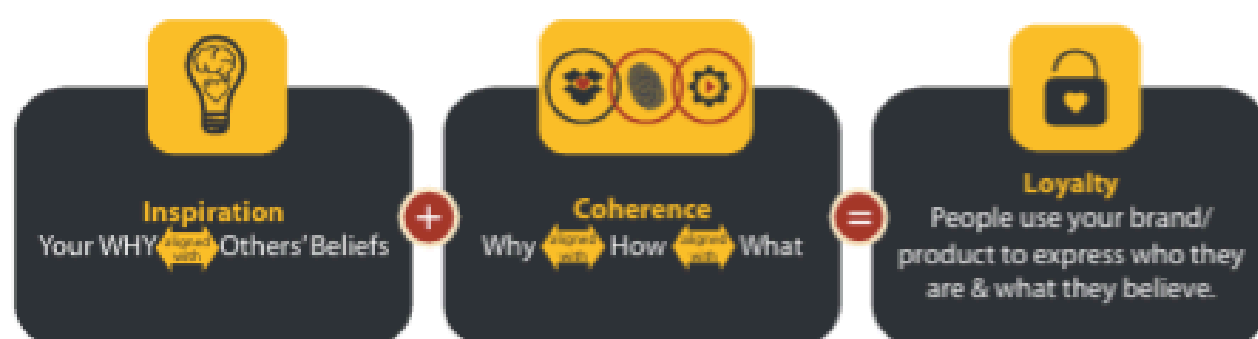


3 levels of certainty

The Golden Circle helps us to understand why some brands can build a strong or even cult-like following.

-  When we use the neocortex to make rational decisions, we think it's the right decision.
-  When we make gut decisions with our limbic brain, we feel it's the right decision.
-  When we can explain our gut feel in words, we involve both aspects of our brains, and we know it's the right decision. This is the highest level of confidence that can be achieved.

Both manipulation and inspiration appeal to our limbic brain. The difference is, **inspiration goes deeper, to relate with who we are and how we view ourselves.** When we're inspired by a product or brand, it becomes a mirror of who we are. It feels right to us and we're prepared to pay a premium (or be inconvenienced) for the products or services. Your brand or product becomes infused with meaning, and **your buyers use it as a symbol to express who they are and what they believe.**



KEY QUOTES

"Most companies are quite adept at winning minds; all that it requires is a comparison of all the features and benefits. Winning hearts, however, takes more work."

"Loyal buyers will always rationalize the premium they pay or the inconvenience they suffer to get that feeling (of trust and value)."

"The ability to put a WHY into words provides the emotional context for decisions."

"When we are inspired, the decisions we make have more to do with who we are and less to do with the companies or the products we're buying."

"For a logo to become a symbol, people must be inspired to use that logo to say something about who they are."



Creating a Following

Two people given the exact same job could view it very differently. One person may find it laborious and boring to build a wall (of a cathedral), while another feels proud to be building a cathedral. Consider these 2 case studies:



Man's first flight. Samuel Pierpont Langley had an ambitious goal to build the world's first flying machine. He was a senior officer at the Smithsonian Institution, an ex-professor from Harvard, and was supported by grants, influential friends, and press coverage. Unfortunately, his key motivation was to become rich and famous; he had no clear WHY. In face of setbacks, he felt humiliated and quit. On the other hand, the Wright brothers didn't have any funding, grants, nor high-level connections. But, they were deeply passionate about solving the scientific and engineering problems of flight, and managed to rally people to help them. After persevering through numerous failures, they made mankind's first flight in 1903.



Civil Rights Movement. In pre-civil rights America, Martin Luther King Jr was not the only person who suffered. Yet, he could start a civil rights movement, because he had such a clear WHY and conviction, that he persevered when others gave up. His famous "I Have a Dream" speech touched people with similar dreams and beliefs, and rallied the masses behind his cause.



Trust: The Key Ingredient

Leaders may hold a rank or position, but **they are only "leading" when people trust them and willingly follow them.** Trust is an irrational feeling that develops when people feel you have their interests at heart. They start to trust you when they understand your beliefs (WHY), and can see that your actions (HOW) and results (WHAT) are aligned with your beliefs.

In business, we do not just want to leverage the power of WHY to generate more sales. **We want to use it to do business with people who share our WHY, so that trust and loyalty can be built.**

KEY QUOTES

"When (the WHY) is clearly understood, it attracts people who believe the same thing."

"Companies with a clear sense of WHY tend to ignore their competition, whereas those with a fuzzy sense of WHY are obsessed with what others are doing."

"WHY is just a belief, HOWs are the actions we take to realize that belief, and WHATs are the results of those actions. When all three are in balance, trust is built and value is perceived."

"There are leaders and there are those who lead."

"Trust is not a checklist... Trust is a feeling, not a rational experience... Trust begins to emerge when we have a sense that another person or organization is driven by things other than their own self-gain."



First, find those who believe

A company is essentially a culture, and common values and beliefs are what hold people together. To build a strong and trusting organization, you should start by finding people who are passionate for your WHY (your belief, cause or purpose), before you assess if they have the right skill sets and experience.

This ensures that you hire people with the right attitudes who can connect at a deeper level. During the 1914 Endurance expedition to explore the Antarctica, the crew was trapped for months in the bitter cold of winter, and had to cross 800 miles of rough seas to seek help. Yet, the team stuck together and no one died despite the insurmountable odds. This was probably because the right people had been hired for the job. Instead of focusing on job scope and experience, the *Endurance* ad had said: "Men wanted for Hazardous journey. Small wages, bitter cold, long months of complete darkness, constant danger, safe return doubtful. Honour and recognition in case of success." The ad attracted survivors – the right people for the job.



Create the right environment

Besides finding the right people, great leaders create a trusting environment where people feel a sense of belonging, and feel safe to take risks, seek advice, and depend on others for support.

- **Continental Airlines** used to have a toxic culture. When Gordon Bethune took over as Chief Executive in 1994, he focused on building trust and an environment where people could win. He made himself accessible and helped the staff to see how cleanliness, better service and turnaround times could benefit themselves (not just customers and the company). He introduced bonuses for everyone when common goals are met, and celebrated small wins. He created a WHY for people to feel like they are in it together.
- **Steve Jobs** did not design Apple's creations himself, nor did he tell people what products to fix. Instead, he provided the purpose and context, within which people were motivated to create and push the boundaries of their creativity.

KEY QUOTES

"The goal is not to hire people who simply have a skill set you need, the goal is to hire people who believe what you believe."

"What all great leaders have in common is the ability to find good fits to join their organizations – those who believe what they believe."

"When you fill an organization with good fits, those who believe what you believe, success just happens."

"When we are selective about doing business only with those who believe in our WHY, trust emerges."

"Pulling together a team of like-minded people and giving them a cause to pursue ensures a greater sense of teamwork and camaraderie."

"No one likes to lose, and most healthy people live their life to win. The only variation is the score we use."

"Average companies give their people something to work on. In contrast, the most innovative organizations give their people something to work toward."

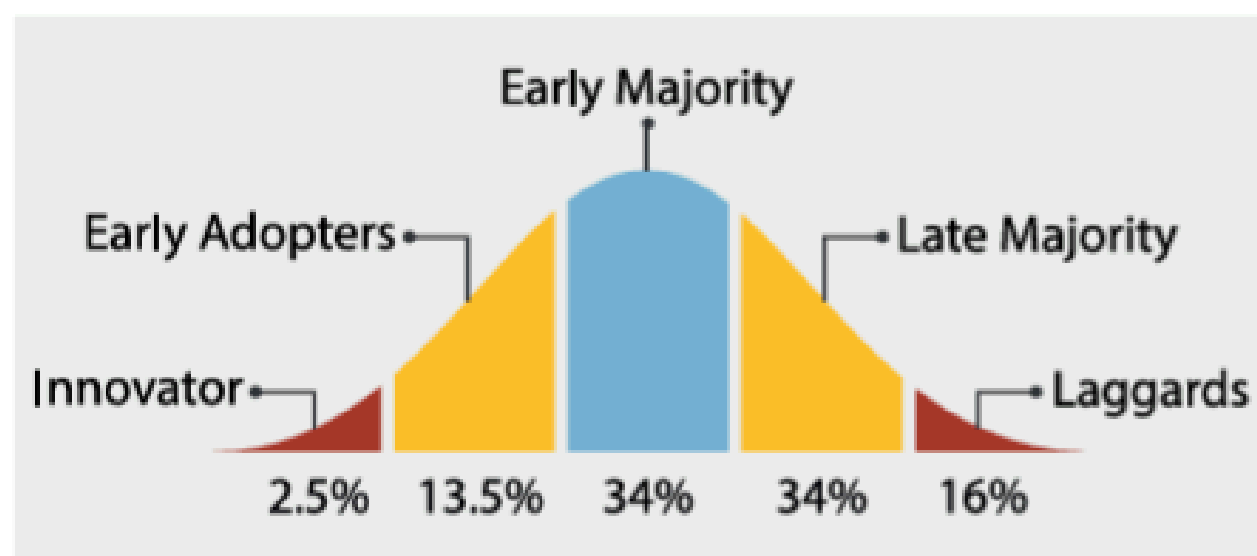
"The role of a leader is not to come up with all the great ideas. The role of a leader is to create an environment in which great ideas can happen."



Creating a Tipping Point

In the book, "The Tipping Point", Malcolm Gladwell shared how connectors and influencers are critical for creating a tipping point. However, he didn't address an important question: why should the influencers help you to spread the word? The answer is, **you need influencers who believe what you believe.**

Sinek explains how innovations, technology and ideas spread, using concepts from "Diffusion of Innovations" by Everett M. Rogers and "Crossing the Chasm" by Geoffrey Moore.



The key message is this – **Focus on finding the 15-18% of innovators and early adopters who believe what you believe, and want to incorporate your ideas and products into their lives.**

- 2.5% of the population are innovators (they challenge others to see the world differently), and 13.5% are early adopters (they see value in the new ideas or technologies and will bear with inconvenience and imperfections to try them). Innovators and early adopters support brands because it's a part of who they are; they are often willing to pay a premium, are more loyal and forgiving.
- The early or late majority typically care less and don't "get it". They are comfortable buying your products only after they see others trying it, which is why you should target your marketing efforts toward the early adopters first. Specifically, according to the Law of Diffusion, you need 15-18% market penetration before the early majority will try it.

KEY QUOTES

"You don't just want any influencer, you want someone who believes what you believe. Only then will they talk about you without any prompts or incentives."

"Trust is a remarkable thing Trust allows us to rely on others."

"The opinions of others matter. And the opinions of those we trust matter most."

"Passion comes from feeling like you are part of something that you believe in, something bigger than yourself."



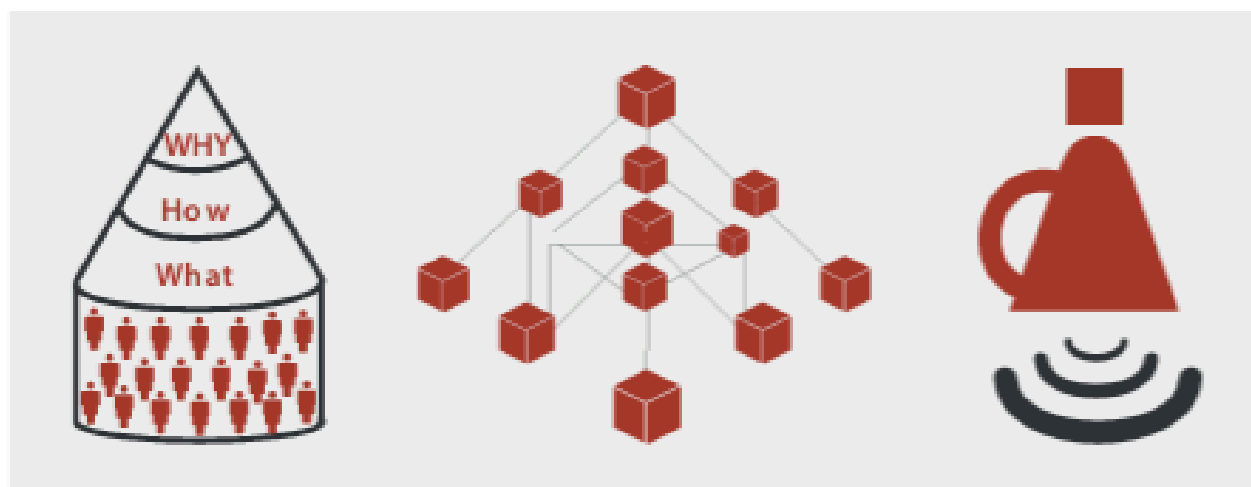
Rally Those who Believe

Injecting energy into an organization can create short-term boosts in employee motivation and action. However, **to inspire and create loyalty, you need charisma, which comes from the clarity of your WHY, and the conviction of your belief or purpose.**

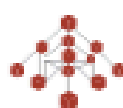
For a message to make an impact and build loyalty, you need:

- **Clarity:** To clearly articulate a higher purpose, cause or belief that others with similar values can relate to; and
- **Amplification:** It must reach enough people to reach a tipping point.

It's like **amplifying your WHY** with a "megaphone". Apply the Golden Circle in 3-dimensions, like a cone:



People with the WHY are visionaries; to succeed, they must partner with people who know the HOW. The leader's vision and charisma attract innovators and adopters, who make sacrifices to help make the vision a reality. Martin Luther King Jr. was supported by Ralph Abernathy, who took the dream and showed people what to do. Steve Jobs was supported by Steve Wozniak, who engineered Apple's early products. Bill Gates was supported by Paul Allen, who built the company.



In an organization, the CEO sits at top of the organization and represents the WHY; he must be surrounded by senior leaders who can help him to translate the HOW, and employees who are able to deliver the WHAT.

- o A vision statement states the founder's intent (WHY the company exists).

KEY QUOTES

"Energy motivates but charisma inspires....Charisma commands loyalty. Energy does not."

"Loyalty to a company trumps pay and benefits...It's the cause we come to work for."

"In every case of a great charismatic leader who ever achieved anything of significance, there was always a person or small group lurking in the shadows who knew HOW to take the vision and make it a reality."

"Those who know WHY need those who know HOW."

"To reach the billion-dollar status, to alter the course of an industry, requires a very special and rare partnership between one who knows WHY and those who know HOW."

"Regardless of WHAT we do in our lives, our WHY - our driving purpose, cause or belief - never changes."

- o A mission statement describes the route or guiding principles (HOW the company will create the future).
- o To succeed, both statements must be aligned, and you must be supported by trust and the right skills. **Our WHAT changes over time, but our WHY doesn't.**



When the WHY is clear, others who share the belief are attracted and want to participate. The belief is amplified and more people are rallied.



The Celery Test

If you didn't know what you wanted to buy, you may go to the supermarket and grab everything – chocolates, cakes, celery, fruits. You spend more money, and people who look at your shopping basket see no pattern. However, if you clearly want a healthy lifestyle and will only eat whole foods, you'll only pick celery and fruits. Your choices are more focused, more cost-effective, and your shopping basket shows a clear theme. Sinek calls this the "Celery Test". A clear WHY can be used as a decision filter for your HOWs and WHATs.



Creating Lasting Success

Many people achieve their goals but feel like failures. That's because **achievement comes when you achieve WHAT you want, while success comes from fulfilling your WHY.** True success is a feeling or state of being which goes deeper. Unfortunately, most of us will reach a point when our WHY and WHAT are misaligned – Sinek calls this the "split".



When WHY Goes Fuzzy

Wal-Mart's founder, Sam Walton, believed that if he looked after people, people would look after him. This was WHY Wal-Mart existed. However, when Sam passed away, the company started to focus on the HOWs and WHATs, and the people-touch was gradually lost. **Sinek shares example after example of companies who have faltered or weakened when the founding leader steps down** – Starbucks losing sight of great personal experience, Dell losing sight of efficiency, Microsoft losing sight of people empowerment.

KEY QUOTES

"What matters more is that WHAT and HOW you do things is consistent with your WHY. Only then will your practices indeed be best."

"Success and achievement are not the same thing, yet too often we mistake one for the other."

"Achievement is something you reach or attain, like a goal. It is something tangible, clearly defined and measurable. Success, in contrast, is a feeling or a state of being."

"The challenge isn't to cling to the leader, it's to find effective ways to keep the founding vision alive forever."

"Those with an ability to never lose sight of WHY, no matter how little or how much they achieve, can inspire us."

When the company is small, the founder's personality is the company's personality. As it grows, systems and structures are put in place. More people start to make decisions, the CEO becomes distanced from the WHAT, and the WHY gets diluted.

To ensure lasting success, you must **ensure that the WHAT continues to be aligned with the WHY as the company grows.**



Only hire people who believe in the WHY and know HOW to build it;



Focus your succession plan on finding the right leaders who are inspired by the founding cause, and can lead the future generations in the right direction. Succession is all about continuing the WHY and the vision.



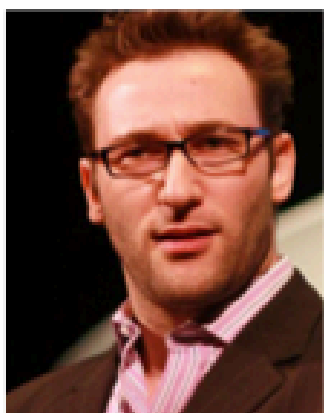
What gets measured, gets done. Constantly apply the "Celery Test" to check that your WHY, HOW and WHAT are aligned.



Conclusion

Finding your WHY is a process of discovery, and the hardest part is not just to discover the WHY, but to stick to it and have the discipline to maintain balance and alignment with your HOWs and WHATs. The book is full of examples to help us understand the concept at work. For more details, please go to www.startwithwhy.com

About the Author



Simon O. Sinek (born 1973) is an author, speaker, and consultant who writes on leadership and management. He joined the RAND Corporation in 2010 as an adjunct staff member, where he advises on matters of military innovation and planning.

He is best known for popularizing the concepts of "the golden circle" and to "Start With Why".

KEY QUOTES

"Successful succession is more than selecting someone with an appropriate skill set - it's about finding someone who is in lockstep with the original cause around which the company was founded....That's why we call it succession, not replacement. There is a continuity of vision."

"Finding WHY is a process of discovery, not invention."